



MONTHLY UPDATE

South Sudan: monthly update, July – August 2026

Edition of 2026-08-31 · 24 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH · GOVERNANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Summary of the month

Two accounts of the identity system were published within a week of each other. The World Bank's ID4D diagnostic put [close to 90% of the population without government-recognised identification](#) and [about 90% of births unrecorded](#) on 22 July 2026; six days later the civil-registry directorate [announced a centralised register and a digital national identity card for every adult](#), naming no law, budget, timetable, vendor or platform.

The revenue authority [barred cash payment of tax at its own offices on 25 July](#) while leaving the digital channel running, and the telecommunications regulator [completed a second increase in the cost of connection on 26 July](#) without publishing the new prices.

Governance

Legislation and regulation

On 5 August 2026 the information minister [briefed the President on establishing an ICT Authority as a state entity under the ICT ministry](#), to regulate internet service providers. The report states the initiative aims to put a regulator in place while the government awaits the passage of legislation through parliament. Neither point that follows is addressed: a body constituted before its statute has no enforcement powers over the providers it is meant to license, and the country already has a National Communication Authority, so the division of competence is unstated. The stated justification is youth employment. An account of 21 May 2026 states that the President signed the Authority's legal framework; the two have not been reconciled.

The other statute in play has a text and a process behind it. The central bank and parliament [opened a five-day workshop on 10 August to validate the National Payment System Bill, 2025](#), covering mobile money, electronic money, payment switches and real-time gross settlement with licensing, consumer-protection and systemic-risk provisions, backed by the East African Community secretariat and the Bank of Uganda. On 17 August the governor [called for faster progress toward passage](#), framing it as the condition for reducing the country's reliance on cash. No bill text, introduction date or parliamentary timetable is held, and the national instant payment system it would license has been Planned since early 2025.

Regional collaboration

The one regional move in the window is a pledge without a workplan. On 12 August the minister [visited the African Telecommunications Union's Nairobi headquarters and pledged deeper collaboration on infrastructure, capacity building and standardisation](#). No workplan, contribution or membership status is stated, and it sits alongside the payment-system bill validated the same month with East African Community and Bank of Uganda backing — the substantive regional support in this record runs through that bill rather than through the union.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

The regulator completed the second stage of its tariff exchange-rate adjustment effective midnight on 26 July 2026; phase one had taken effect on 26 June. MTN South Sudan, Zain South Sudan and Digitel all [raised voice, data and SMS charges, citing inflation, fuel costs, network maintenance paid in foreign currency and depreciation of the South Sudanese pound](#), running base stations largely on diesel generators for want of grid power. Neither the regulator nor the operators [disclosed the revised rates or said whether further phases will follow](#), and the regulator maintains this is a revision of the exchange rate used to calculate charges rather than a tariff increase.

On 20 July the regulator closed a two-day inception workshop launching development of a [National Spectrum Management and 5G Strategy](#) with the ICT ministry, the Eastern Africa Regional Digital Integration Project and an expert team. Its outputs were a methodology, a work plan and governance structures; no spectrum plan, band allocation or timetable is published.

On 29 July, leaders of Kauto Administrative Area in Eastern Equatoria [stated that the area has mobile coverage only at Kuron and that four further sites have been requested for years without explanation for the delay](#). The chief administrator said information from three settlements can take one to two weeks to reach his office, arriving by road with travellers. Leaders reported that operators raised doubts about revenue from the area, and a coverage extension expected from February 2026 has not materialised.

DPI

Digital Identity and CRVS

The World Bank published its ID4D country diagnostic on 22 July 2026, putting [close to 90% of the population without any government-recognised identification](#). It records that obtaining the Nationality Certificate, the prerequisite for the identity card, requires costly age assessments or blood tests and travel to centralised offices, so most people acquire neither.

On 28 July the civil-registry directorate's plan also included [a digital national identity card to be issued to every citizen aged 18 and over as the gateway to bank accounts](#), delivery running through the health, justice and interior ministries with unnamed partners. It is [stated as intent only](#): no law, budget, timetable, vendor or platform is named.

The directorate says a [new-generation passport will be introduced in August 2027](#), moving the holder's occupation off the printed page into the digital system; raising ordinary validity from five to ten years, and issuing the East African Community passport, would each require amending the passport act, and no legislative timetable is given. It also [received 37,500 further passport booklets, putting stock at enough to sustain issuance to December 2026](#) with processing at about three days, and in Greater Yei [over 4,000 national identity cards began being collected on 13 July](#).

The directorate changed hands on 9 August, and both officeholders put numbers on the record. The outgoing director put stock at about 32,000 passport booklets and 172,000 national identity cards, alongside 100 new mobile registration kits, a Nairobi memorandum toward an integrated civil registration system, and adult passport validity extended to ten years — claims made at his own handover about his own tenure. His successor put annual applicants above one million and delays at about a month, pledging faster and corruption-free issuance.

The largest registration actually carried out in the window was not the state's. The migration agency ran a biometric registration and re-registration exercise across the Malakal protection-of-civilians site, the Bulakat transit centre and the Bentiu displacement camp, serving about 160,000 people between April and June, and its community-feedback data records an 1,100% rise in queries over the quarter, driven almost entirely by that exercise. No data-controller arrangement, retention rule, consent record or relationship to the national identity system is stated for it.

Digital Payments and Fintech

On 25 July, following a resolution of the Ministerial High-Level Committee on Economic Reform, the revenue authority barred cash payment of tax at its offices. Liabilities in South Sudanese pounds must be deposited at designated banks and evidenced by an official slip before a receipt is issued; dollar-assessed taxes keep existing arrangements, and digital payment through Capital Pay continues. The authority states it as temporary.

Registries

The same World Bank diagnostic put approximately 90% of births going unrecorded, recording that civil registration is largely non-operational.

On 28 July the civil-registry directorate set out a plan under which health facilities would notify births rather than issue certificates, the directorate would become the sole issuing authority, births, deaths, marriages and divorces would sit in one national database, and death registration would become compulsory. It is stated as intent only: no law, budget, timetable, vendor or platform is named.

Sectoral management information systems

On 5 August the education ministry launched an Education in Emergencies Management Information System on the DHIS2 platform with UNESCO and the HISP Centre, funded by Education Cannot Wait, after training 35 master trainers; twelve County Education Departments have been equipped with solar power, computers and connectivity to feed it.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

On 20 July revised fees were published on the electronic visa portal, putting US\$50 on citizens of Kenya, Uganda, Rwanda and DR Congo and US\$100 on Somali, Burundian and Nigerian citizens.

Capacity

Training and skills

On 30 July the Central Equatoria state ministry of information announced a Digital Innovation for Skills and Knowledge programme: three digital skills centres in Juba and Yei training more than 8,000 people, put by the state information minister at 5,000 residents and 3,000 civil servants. The implementing partner put the budget at US\$2,806,100. No financier, signed commitment or start date was named.

Inclusion

Access to services

The cost of connection rose for the second time in two months when the [second phase of the tariff exchange-rate adjustment took effect on 26 July 2026](#), with no revised rates published by the regulator or the operators. Against a baseline of [about US\\$23.70 per gigabyte in November 2025](#), there is now no published price for mobile data in the country.

Prices completed their third rise of the year and the record still cannot say by how much. Operators [applied the regulator's third and final tariff exchange-rate adjustment phase from midnight on 17 August](#), raising call and data prices against inflation, currency depreciation and hard-currency access problems. No phase has published its rates. [A 25% cut in December 2025](#) has now been overtaken three times, which leaves affordability in this market a direction of travel with no quantity attached to it.

Data

National statistics

On 23 July the National Bureau of Statistics [published a demographic projection putting the population at about 16.36 million by end-2026 and 19.99 million by 2030](#), against 13.2 million in 2021, of which some 2.2 million is attributed to migration from the Sudan conflict.

Geopolitics

China activities

On 31 August the ICT minister was reported to have [held exploratory talks with a Huawei vice-president in Hangzhou](#), on the sidelines of a China-Africa digital capacity building conference, saying the government is ready to seek the company's expertise in connecting public services. Beyond e-governance, participation is sought in building smart cities, providing energy solutions and setting up a national data hub in Juba.

This is a repair, not an opening. Government officials accused the company in 2014 of hacking government emails and forging documents; it stayed in the market through the rift, connecting schoolchildren to the internet and refurbishing school laboratories, and the restoration is credited to two officials who took post in 2025, whose [meeting in Juba in early 2026 covered the digital divide, the data hub and a smart capital](#). Nothing has been agreed: no contract, memorandum, workstream or figure is on record, which is where this relationship stood in February and where it still stands.

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